

Market Research & Pricing Intelligence

Guide for Small Businesses

How to find prices, incumbents, and competitive intelligence for state and federal contracts — so you can price your first proposal to win.

Guide Key:

FEDERAL

STATE

FEDERAL + STATE

Steps apply to both procurement levels

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FEDERAL

Start with USASpending.gov (Federal)

The official source for all federal contract awards. Search by keyword, NAICS code, agency, or vendor name. Filter by award date to see recent pricing. Export results to CSV for deeper analysis — this is your pricing baseline for federal work.

■ *Key action: Search your NAICS code + filter last 2 years → review award amounts per contract*

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FEDERAL

Mine SAM.gov Award Notices for Pricing Intelligence

SAM.gov publishes award notices for contracts once they are awarded. These notices often include the winning vendor, total award value, period of performance, and contract type. Study these notices to understand what agencies paid and who won — this is public data you are entitled to use.

■ *Pro tip: Search your NAICS code under 'Award Notices' and sort by recent awards to build a pricing benchmark*

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FEDERAL

Use FPDS-NG for Incumbent & Award History

The Federal Procurement Data System (fpds.gov) tracks every federal contract action. Search by NAICS, PSC code, or agency to find who holds current contracts, award values, periods of performance, and whether the contract was competed or sole-sourced.

■ *Key data: Contractor name + award amount + competition type tells you who to watch and what they charge*

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FEDERAL

Research GSA Schedule Pricing (Federal Labor Rates)

GSA Multiple Award Schedules publish approved labor rates for thousands of contractors. Use GSA Advantage (gsaadvantage.gov) or the GSA eLibrary to look up ceiling rates for your labor categories — this anchors your pricing to a fair market standard.

■ *Resource: gsa.gov/buy-through-us/purchasing-programs/gsa-multiple-award-schedules*

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FEDERAL

Check the SCA Wage Determinations

The Service Contract Act (SCA) sets minimum wage floors for service contracts. The Wage and Hour Division publishes Wage Determinations (WDs) by location and occupation. Your labor pricing must meet or exceed these — ignoring them will disqualify your proposal.

■ *Resource: sam.gov/wages — search by state, county, and occupation code before pricing any labor*

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STATE

Find State Incumbents via State Procurement Portals

Every state has a procurement portal listing active and awarded contracts. Search your service category to find current vendors, award values, and contract durations. Most states publish awardee names and amounts — your incumbents are hiding in plain sight.

■ *Examples: Texas — txsmartbuy.gov | Virginia — eva.virginia.gov | Florida — myfloridamarketplace.com*

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STATE

Use NIGP Codes for State Contract Research

States use National Institute of Governmental Purchasing (NIGP) commodity codes — the state equivalent of NAICS codes. Identify your NIGP codes first, then filter state contract databases by those codes to find comparable awards and pricing.

■ *Tip: Many states list NIGP codes on awarded contracts — use them to cross-reference similar work*

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BOTH

Review Existing Contract Vehicles & BPAs

Blanket Purchase Agreements (BPAs), IDIQs, and state master contracts often publish pricing schedules. If a target agency uses a vehicle (like SEWP, CIO-SP3, or a state-wide contract), find that vehicle's pricing structure and benchmark against it.

■ *Federal vehicles to check: GSA MAS, SEWP V, CIO-SP3, NASA SEWP, OASIS, 8(a) STARS III*

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BOTH

Analyze Competitors Using LinkedIn & SAM Registrations

SAM.gov shows registered vendors by NAICS and certification type. Cross-reference with LinkedIn to understand your competitors' size, staffing, and capabilities. Smaller firms often underprice to win — larger ones rely on past performance premium.

■ *Intel move: Search the incumbent company + contract number on LinkedIn to find their project staff*

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BOTH

Build Your Price-to-Win Model

Aggregate your research into a simple spreadsheet: list competitors, their known rates, contract sizes, and win history. Add 10–15% margin for overhead and profit on top of direct costs. Price to be competitive, not just to cover costs — the goal is to win.

■ *Rule of thumb: If your price is more than 15% above the lowest comparable award, re-examine your cost structure*

**Build Your
Research Stack:**

Bookmark these five free tools before your next proposal: **USASpending.gov** (federal awards), **fpds.gov** (federal incumbent data), **SAM.gov/wages** (SCA wage determinations), **GSA Advantage** (labor rate ceilings), and your **state procurement portal** (state incumbents & award history). Together they give you the pricing intelligence to submit a competitive, defensible proposal.